

TAKING THE LEAD
PM Modi with tribal elders at an election rally in Mahasamand, Chhattisgarh, in late April

Photographs by ANI

CHRISTIAN TRIBALS WHO ARE PART OF THE BJP IN MAHARASHTRA ARE UPSET AT THE SANGH DEMAND TO EXCLUDE 'CONVERTED' MEMBERS FROM THE ST CATEGORY

states of Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka and Telangana, where regional forces also hold sway.

Unease on the ground

In Maharashtra, the BJP holds all the four constituencies reserved for STs—Palghar, Dindori, Nandurbar and Gadchiroli—and the Sangh Parivar's Vanvasi Kalyan Ashram (VKA) has a strong presence in the state. But despite the access to education, job opportunities are few. "Scholarships have dried up while recruitment for government and public sector jobs has also shrunk. Landlessness among the tribals is rising as they make way for development projects and dams," says Suhas Naik, Congress leader and vice-president of the Nandurbar zilla parishad, voicing sentiments that echo across the tribal lands in the country.

The community's fears on reservations and the UCC are also real. For instance, Christian tribals in north Maharashtra's Navapur taluka of Nandurbar district who have joined the BJP are upset at the Sangh demand to exclude 'converted tribals' from the ST category. At the same time, the demand for the inclusion of the OBC Dhangar shepherd community—a cohort that the BJP has been assiduously